this sort of challenge, they need to have a solid understanding of what business value is expected from the system.

At the end of the day, business people want the software being built to help them achieve their business goals. If the software delivers in this regard, the business will consider it a success, even if the scope and implementation vary considerably from what was originally imagined. But if the software fails to meet the underlying business goals, then it will rightly be considered a failure, even if it meets the requirements provided by the customers down to the letter.

3.4.1 Writing good business goals

Business goals are high-level statements that focus on business value or opportunity, statements that executives would be able to relate to and discuss. For example, one of the more important business goals for the Frequent Flyer program discussed earlier might be the following:

```
Increase ticket sales by 5% over the next year by encouraging travellers to
    fly with Flying High rather than with a rival company.
```

A statement like this has the merit of clarifying the "why" of the project: why exactly are you building this software? But like the project vision, business goals are often very poorly communicated. Many development teams have only a vague notion of the business goals they're trying to deliver. And yet, understanding these goals is essential to making correct scope, design, and implementation choices during the project.

You can also write goals using the following "In order to ... As a ... I want to ..." format:

```
In order to increase ticket sales by 5% over the next year
As the Flying High Sales Manager
I want to encourage travellers to fly with Flying High rather than with a
    rival company
```

This is a variation on the more traditional "As a ... I want ... so that ..." form used in many project teams for story cards. This form puts the goal first ("In order to ...") as opposed to the more traditional user story format, where the stakeholder is placed in the primary position. Putting the goal first places the emphasis on the expected outcome, which should be of obvious value to the business. When the stakeholder comes first, the last section ("so that ...") tends to be eclipsed, and you may find yourself proposing high-level capabilities and then struggling to justify them with a solid business goal.

This is a very versatile format, and you'll use it to describe requirements at various levels of abstraction throughout the book.

Whatever format you prefer, a good business goal should be precise. Some business managers use the SMART acronym: business goals should be

- Specific
- Measurable
- Achievable
- Relevant
- Time-bound